



CAN ITALY DO IT AGAIN?

Defending champion Italy **aims for glory once again** while Spain, rejuvenated under Luis de la Fuente, looks strong with fresh talent.

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Italy's journey has been unusual. After failing to qualify for the 2018 World Cup, it went on a 37-game unbeaten run under Roberto Mancini and won Euro 2020. However, it failed to qualify for the World Cup again in 2022 in Qatar.

As the defending champion, Italy should feel inspired. Luciano Spalletti, who took over after Mancini's resignation, is at the helm. With Spalletti preferring the 4-3-3 formation, Italy will look for a solid back four, supported by a defensive midfielder, making Jorginho crucial.

In defence, Destiny Udogie's injury is unfortunate, but uncapped Andrea Cambiaso has a chance to impress. Inter Milan's Federico Dimarco and Alessandro Bastoni are almost certain to start.

Searching for stability: Under new coach Luciano Spalletti, Italy will look to shore up its squad in time for its title defence. GETTY IMAGES

Italy's attack is a concern, with Spalletti lacking a world-class No. 9. Europa League winner Gianluca Scamacca has just one goal in 15 appearances while Federico Chiesa will hope to find his Euro 2020 form.

Dark horses no more

The phrases 'Dark Horse' and 'Giant Killer' were often associated with Croatia, but it has moved past the underdog trope. Croatia's 'Golden Generation' is ageing, and several players have retired from international football, but its consistency makes it difficult to count it out on the big stage.

Midfield is Croatia's strongest department, featuring Luka Modrić (left; in blue), Mateo Kovačić, and Marcelo Brozovic. However, at 38, Modrić's match time needs to be managed properly by Zlatko Dalić to get the best out of the Croatia captain.



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